

Red Flag Reference Sheet

Observe for the following Red Flag historical and physical findings. The presence of two or more of these signs and symptoms can indicate the need for outside care referral or immediate transfer for urgent or emergent care.

Red Flag Conditions

- Cardiovascular and Cerebrovascular Disease - Acute Coronary Syndrome and Stroke
- Fractures and high-grade tendon/muscle sprains/strains (significant partial and complete tears)
- Nerve (peripheral, spinal) impingement and damage
- DVT and Pulmonary Embolism
- Infections (soft tissue, bone, spine, urinary track, kidney, others)
- Concussion and Traumatic Brain Injury
- Compartment Syndrome
- Cancer
- Other diseases

Red Flag Mechanism of Injury

- Fall from heights
- High velocity/impact struck-by or struck-against trauma
- Head injuries
- Whiplash type injuries
- Falling on outstretched hand
- Puncture or penetrating wounds
- Eye trauma
- Lacerations
- High pressure injection injury

Red Flag Symptoms

- Chest pain, shortness of breath, dyspnea on exertion, chest pain radiating to jaw or shoulder/arm/upper back pain, nausea, and vomiting, pallor, diaphoresis (profuse sweating)
- Loss of function and significant restrictions in range of motion
- Severe pain – Worsening Pain – Intractable Pain – Chronic pain
- Increased/severe pain with movement or weight-bearing
- Loss of sensation, numbness, tingling and weakness, progressive neurological symptoms, loss of or changes in bowel/bladder function, loss of or changes in consciousness, mental status changes
- Calf pain, temperature/color changes in extremities
- Generalized weakness, malaise, pallor, nausea and vomiting, unexplained weight loss, fevers/chills/night sweats, loss of appetite could suggest infection, cancer, or another serious condition
- Worsening symptoms unresponsive to first aid

Red Flag Signs and Physical Findings

- Marked edema, ecchymosis, hematoma, and joint effusions
- Soft tissue or bony deformities observed and/or palpated
- Point bony tenderness, especially on the spine, with other signs and symptoms of possible fracture
- Guarded/loss of ROM
- Inability to bear weight, move or use affected body part
- Sensory loss, motor deficits and muscle atrophy
- Decreased, asymmetrical deep tendon reflexes
- Decreased and/or asymmetrical pulses, temperature, and color changes in extremity (vascular compromise and/or autonomic involvement)
- Tense, painful upper or lower extremity compartment, painful with movement
- Signs of infection such as erythema, edema, calor, and lymphangitis (red streaks)
- Red, swollen and/or warm joints
- Symptom magnification

Consider Potential PMH Red Flags as Indicated

- Heart disease, CVD, cancer, osteoporosis, hypertension, diabetes, blood clots/bleeding disorders, anticoagulant Rx